mandated by international law, the Rohingyas are likely to become highly susceptible to any radical group prepared to offer humanitarian aid, education and health care. There are already instances of individual Rohingya men joining groups such as Lashkar-e-Taiba in Pakistan. How long before the lack of friendship from the government of India translates into friendships with its enemies?

For obvious reasons of geography and poverty, most Rohingyas have tried to flee into Bangladesh. Unfortunately, Bangladesh has a long history of ignoring the plight of the Rohingyas and of forcing refugees back into Myanmar. This started in the 1970s and continues to this day. At the moment, Bangladesh is trying to force the new arrivals to stay in large camps on the border and has forbidden them from travelling into the rest of the country. A positive interpretation is that this is, as claimed by the Bangladeshi authorities, a means to organise relief efforts. However, such camps are squalid and overcrowded and the Rohingyas have the lessons of recent history as a reason to mistrust Bangladesh's intentions. The Rohingyas are thus far from salvation even once they manage to escape the clutches of the Myanmar military.

What we have in the Rohingyas is an extremely precarious population, divided into densely populated and under-provisioned refugee camps, spread across three countries, with some tentative connections to radical groups especially in Pakistan and Saudi Arabia, and with a new, developing inclination towards insurgency, led by ARSA. This is a recipe for absolute disaster not just for the Rohingyas themselves, but for the entire region.

The emergence of a group like ARSA is predictable and depressing. Predictable because sooner or later an ethnic group left with no hope will strike back at its persecutors. Depressing, because the attacks by ARSA certainly triggered the violence in August and September 2017 against the Rohingyas. The emergence of ARSA also fits neatly into the preferred narrative of the Myanmar state that it is facing a sustained terrorist threat to its very existence.

In addition, if conditions for refugees do not improve, and ethnic cleansing continues within Rakhine, the likelihood is that ARSA will not lack for recruits. Thus a situation that till recently was marked by peaceful resistance by the Rohingyas is likely to shift to a low-level insurgency, at the very least. In that situation, there are plenty of extremists—both